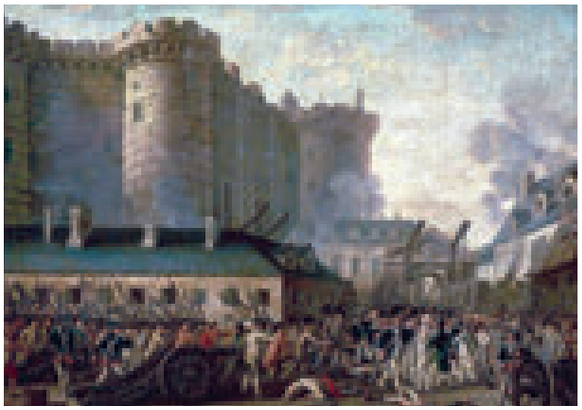
Course of the French Revolution

The Fall of Bastille



Fall of the Bastille

The critical moment came after the king shut out the commoners and the latter assembled in the Tennis-Court and took an oath that they would not disperse until they found a way out to their problems. The King tried to use force but his own soldiers refused to obey his orders. Louis then intrigued to get foreign regiments to shoot down his own people. This provoked the people to rise in revolt in Paris on 14 July 1789. They stormed the Bastille prison and set free all the prisoners. The fall of the Bastille was the first great turning point in the revolution. 14 July is celebrated as the National Day of France to this day. The subsequent popular risings all over the country emboldened the National Assembly to act swiftly.

National Assembly

This Assembly comprised moderate liberals, who wanted a constitution on the model of England and America. Their leader was Mirabeau. The Assembly was controlled by the middle classes and there was no representation to the peasants and the common masses. This National Assembly abolished serfdom, feudal privileges, including exempting nobles and clergy from taxation, even titles, and feudal courts. The Assembly then passed a Declaration of the Rights of the Man and the Citizen.



Mirabeau

Declaration of the Rights of the Man and the Citizen: This declaration was drafted by Lafayette, Thomas Jefferson and Mirabeau. Based on Natural Law, that asserts that certain rights are inherent by virtue of human nature, the rights of humans were declared universal… and valid at all times and in every place. Inspired by the Enlightenment philosophers, the Declaration was a core statement of the values of the French Revolution and had a major impact on the development of freedom and democracy worldwide.

The idea was taken from the American Declarati`on of Independence. But the American declaration is short, while the French one is long. The Rights of Man include the rights which were supposed to ensure him equality and liberty and happiness. The Assembly brought about many other reforms. The vast property of the Church was confiscated by the State. A new division of France was made into eighty departments. The old feudal courts were replaced by better law-courts.

March to Versailles



March to Versailles

IX History 3rd Term_English version CHAPTER 09.indd 122 02-04-2019 13:04:00